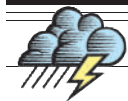


The Washington Post

Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

RE V1 V2 V3 V4



Heavy t-storm 91/67 • Tomorrow: Mostly sunny 89/69 **B6**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, JUNE 19, 2025 • \$4

Ban upheld on gender transition for minors

Supreme Court sides with Tennessee; 20-plus states have similar laws

BY ANN E. MARIMOW AND CASEY PARKS

Tennessee can ban gender transition treatments for minors, a divided Supreme Court ruled Wednesday in a landmark decision on a polarizing issue the Trump administration has seized on as it targets transgender rights.

In one of the most high-profile cases of the term, the court voted 6-3 along ideological lines to uphold the state law that prohibits adolescents from using hormones and puberty blockers for gender transition.

The decision, authored by Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr., has implications for more than 20 other states that have banned similar treatments as a growing — but still small — number of young people seek gender transition care. The ruling appears to leave opportunities for advocates to challenge other policies restricting access for transgender individuals to bathrooms, sports participation, military service and health care.

Roberts said Tennessee's law does not discriminate on the basis of sex and that courts must give elected officials wide discretion to pass legislation when there is scientific and policy debate about the safety of medical treatments in an evolving field. He acknowledged that "The voices in these debates raise sincere concerns; the implications for all are profound."

SEE SUPREME COURT ON A6

Japanese firm finishes \$14B takeover of U.S. Steel

BY ABHA BHATTARAI

Nippon Steel has completed its \$14.2 billion takeover of U.S. Steel, the company announced Wednesday, capping a year and a half of fraught negotiations and resulting in a landmark deal for a president who originally opposed the deal.

The agreement includes a "golden share" arrangement that gives President Donald Trump final say over key parts of the company's U.S. business — including plant closures, headquarters location and employee salaries — as a way to ease earlier national security concerns.

Nippon Steel, a Japanese industry giant, bought all shares of U.S. Steel for \$55 apiece, valuing the transaction at \$14.2 billion, corporate filings show. The company also plans to invest an additional \$11 billion in its U.S. operations by 2028. Combined, the new company will become the world's second-largest steel-maker, giving it a leg up in an industry largely dominated by China.

Nippon Steel's stock price rose by 1.9 percent following the news Wednesday, although it is still down more than 7 percent from the beginning of this year.

"This is a significant deal both economically and in terms of the precedent it sets for foreign investment," said Kristi Govella, senior adviser at the Center for

SEE STEEL ON A14

0 say can you see



TOM BRENNER/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

President Donald Trump and others watch the American flag as it's raised on the South Lawn on Wednesday. "It's such a beautiful pole," the president said earlier in the day as massive new flagpoles were erected on the North and South Lawns, the most notable exterior modification to the White House since he returned to the presidency.

Fearful lawmakers reckon with how to keep safe

BY PATRICK MARLEY, YVONNE WINGETT SANCHEZ, HOLLY BAILEY AND KYLE MELNICK

Minnesota officials weigh protecting themselves while staying accessible

ST. PAUL, MINN. — Minnesota lawmakers, terrified by predawn attacks on two of their own, turned to each other on a group text for comfort. A colleague had been killed and another had been shot, and the accused gunman was still on the loose. The 20 Democrats grieved and shared prayers — and began exchanging safety tips as they learned some of them were on the suspect's list of targets.

"I'm hunkered down," one wrote Saturday morning after learning that authorities said the suspect had assembled a list of

dozens of Democratic targets across the Midwest. "Will stay put. But I feel so sick."

The suspect was caught and charged a day later, but the legislators' fears did not end. State lawmakers — who tend to be far more accessible than their federal counterparts — are weighing new safety precautions and considering whether they should erect new barriers with voters to protect themselves from the public. They see changes as inevitable,

but some fear they could chip away at their ability to connect with their communities and hear directly from the citizens they represent.

In the group chat, obtained by The Washington Post under the condition that the names of the senders would not be published, the lawmakers told each other what they were hearing from police. One texted about their friend being in heaven. Another wrote that Sunday Communion was being brought to her. Others offered birthday messages to a colleague who was holed up in her apartment. They began scrubbing their home addresses from publicly available websites.

The arrest Sunday of Vance Boelter brought some relief but

left room for new worries. Prosecutors alleged Boelter had shown up at two other legislators' homes as he stalked the suburbs of the Twin Cities, driving an SUV loaded with weapons and outfitted to look like a police car.

"It just makes us all feel so much more vulnerable," said Sen. Sandra Pappas (D), who has served in the legislature for four decades.

State legislators don't draw as much attention as members of Congress even though they often pass consequential laws. In Minnesota and across the nation, they rely on frequent in-person contact

SEE SAFETY ON A4

Manhunt: The more than 40-hour search for the shooting suspect. **A5**

NIH layoffs put urgent cancer therapy on hold

Purge of probationary workers included skilled lab personnel with potential life-or-death ramifications

BY CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON

Richard Schlueter, 56, was planting cucumbers and squash in his community garden plot in Greensboro, Georgia, in May when he tore open a bag of soil and heard a pop. His collarbone had snapped.

In early June, a scan revealed that the cancer that started in his tonsils was racing through his bones. That day, he called a medical team at the National Institutes of Health that had created an experimental cell therapy, custom-made to attack his cancer as part of a clinical trial. He needed it. Now.

Instead, he received more bad news: His therapy would be delayed at least a month because of staff cuts at NIH.

A week later, Schlueter and his wife, Michelle, saw NIH Director Jay Bhattacharya push back on concerns raised by his own staff that the ouster of essential employees and other disruptions to the biomedical research agency

SEE CANCER ON A18



AUDRA MELTON/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Richard and Michelle Schlueter with their dog, Irish, at home this week in Brookhaven, Georgia.

Trump says he warned Iranians

ULTIMATUM GIVEN ON NUCLEAR WORK

President is coy on any plans for joining conflict

BY NATALIE ALLISON AND MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

President Donald Trump delivered an "ultimate ultimatum" to Iranian leaders to dismantle their nuclear program, he told reporters on Wednesday. But he said he has not made a final decision about whether to strike Iran and draw Washington into a new conflict in the Middle East.

Standing on the South Lawn of the White House, Trump was coy about his plans for a potential war with Iran. He said that "the next week is going to be big" and maintained that Iranian officials are eager to negotiate, but he explained that after Iranians reached out to him, he warned them that "it's very late to be talking."

"Will you strike the Iranian nuclear component, and what time exactly, sir?" Trump replied mockingly when asked whether he was moving toward ordering U.S. forces to bomb Iran, adding that he couldn't seriously answer the question.

In fact, Trump had already reviewed potential plans to attack Iran, an official with knowledge of the situation told The Washington Post. Like others, they spoke on the condition of anonymity to

SEE IRAN ON A10

THE DEBRIEF

‘We’ll see’: Unpredictable Trump stays true to form

BY MATT VISER

Does he want to be a wartime president, or the broker of peace? Can he convince his MAGA base that going to war with Iran isn't the kind of Middle Eastern entanglement he has spent more than a decade warning against? Is the moment for diplomacy over, or are the Iranians coming to the White House?

He himself doesn't seem to yet know.

"You don't seriously think I'm going to answer that question," President Donald Trump said, when asked Wednesday morning if he had made a decision on U.S. strikes in Iran. "You don't know that I'm going to even do it. You know, I may do it. I may not do it. I mean, nobody knows what I'm going to do."

It was the unpredictable president, once again, being unpredictable. It is still unclear whether his vague but muscular warnings are laying the groundwork for a military attack or something more strategically complex, part of a diplomatic gambit to steer a foreign adversary into a deal favorable to him and not to them.

SEE DEBRIEF ON A11

Hezbollah: Iranian-backed militant group is staying out of the fray. **A10**

Brain trust: In crisis, Trump turns to experience over star power. **A12**

IN THE NEWS

Acquittal in retrial Karen Read was found not guilty of killing her boyfriend, one year after a mistrial on identical charges in a case that was a tabloid and true-crime fixture. **A8**

Metrobus overhaul Big changes are coming to the D.C. transit service on June 29, as the system works toward a regional network. **B1**

THE NATION
Barring a revamp, Social Security and Medicare will face cuts by 2033, a report said. **A2**
The State Department is restarting student visa interviews with tougher social media rules. **A18**

THE WORLD
A statue of George Washington, refurbished after a century, dismays in London. **A9**
An erupting volcano in Indonesia sent an ash cloud six miles high and disrupted travel. **A12**

THE ECONOMY
The Senate tax bill would reward oil drillers while cutting large swaths of funding for wind and solar. **A13**
The Federal Reserve kept interest rates steady as it continued to gauge the fallout from Trump's trade war and other policies. **A14**

THE REGION
Virginia is set to make history in November, no matter which ticket wins, after its primary elections. **B1**
A 34-year-old man was convicted of murder in the July 2023 killing of a Maryland teacher who disappeared while on a walk. **B1**

SPORTS
The Thunder is on the cusp of an NBA title, and its star, Shai Gilgeous-Alexander, is poised to join an elite club. **D1**

LOCAL LIVING
Looking to get rid of a toxic ex? Thousands of spells are for sale on Etsy, with most tagged as "entertainment."

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